

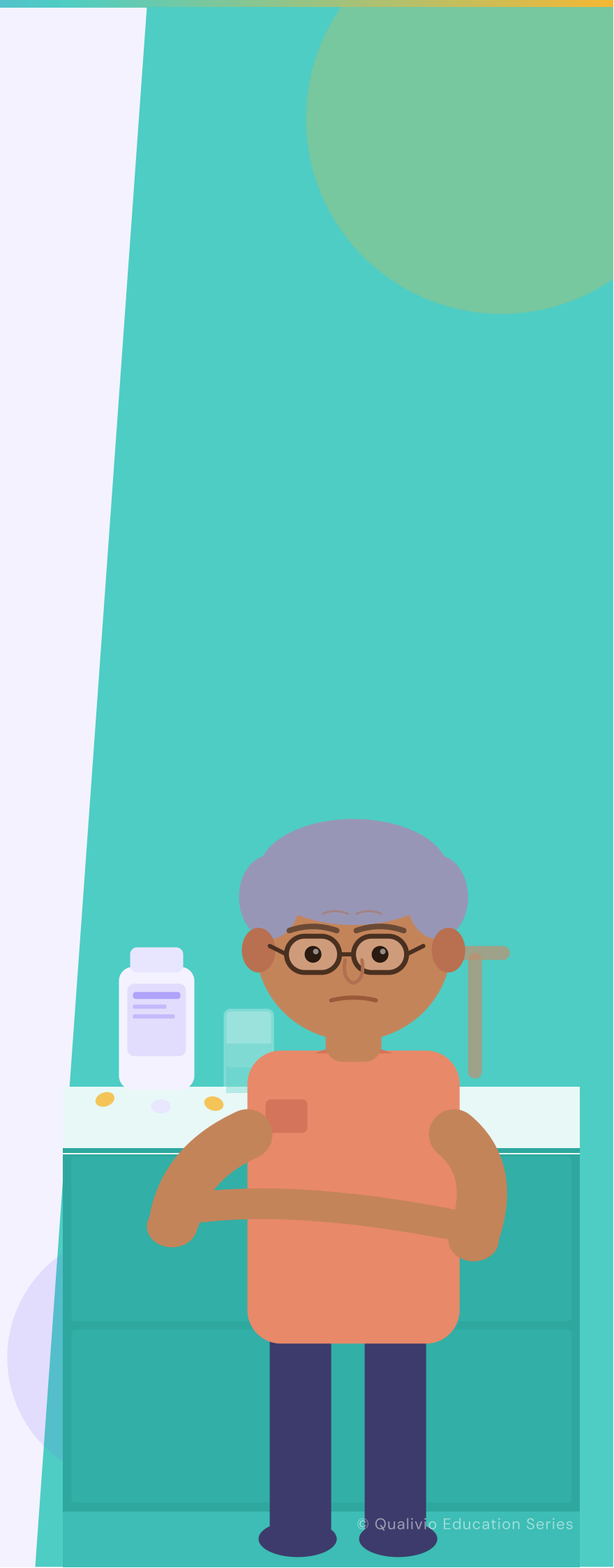
PLAIN LANGUAGE GUIDE

Pharma co vigi lance Made Simple.

The story of Martin, a medicine called Relvian, and how the global drug safety system works.

9 chapters · Plain language · Free guide

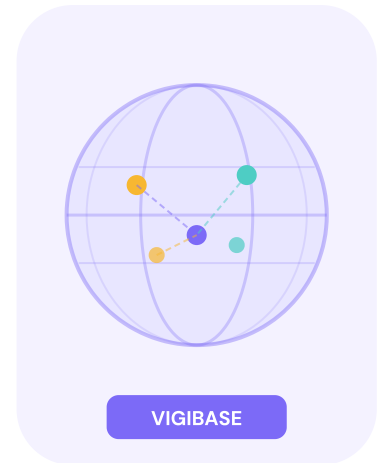
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What is pharmacovigilance?

When a medicine is approved and reaches patients, the clinical trials are over. But the learning has only just begun. Real patients are older, sicker, and often taking other medicines at the same time. Some side effects are too rare to appear during trials. Others only emerge after years of use.

Pharmacovigilance is the international system for monitoring, detecting, and responding to medicine safety issues once a drug is on the market. It involves doctors, pharmacists, patients, regulators, and manufacturers all playing a defined role.



"Pharmacovigilance is the reason a side effect discovered in one country can protect a patient on the other side of the world."

130+

countries in the WHO safety
monitoring network

30M+

reports in VigiBase, the global
safety database

This is Martin.

Martin is 61 years old and has osteoarthritis in his knees. His pain has gradually worsened, and it is no longer well controlled with exercise and occasional over-the-counter pain relief.

HIS CONDITION

Osteoarthritis is a degenerative joint condition that causes pain, stiffness, and reduced mobility. It affects over 500 million people worldwide. For Martin, it is getting worse.



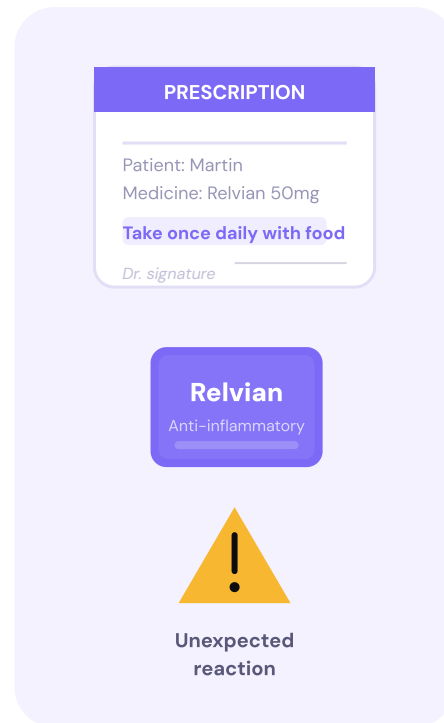
Medical History and Treatment Initiation.

Martin's doctor prescribes him **Relvian**, a new anti-inflammatory medicine that has just come on the market. Martin collects the medicine from his local pharmacy. The pharmacist informs him of the known potential side effects: indigestion, dizziness, and mild headache.

After a week, Martin develops unusual shortness of breath when climbing stairs and a persistent dry cough. He also feels more tired than usual. He wonders if it has something to do with his new medicine. He makes an appointment with his doctor to find out.

KNOWN SIDE EFFECTS AT THIS POINT

Indigestion · Dizziness · Mild headache.
Drug-induced lung inflammation was **not** on the list.



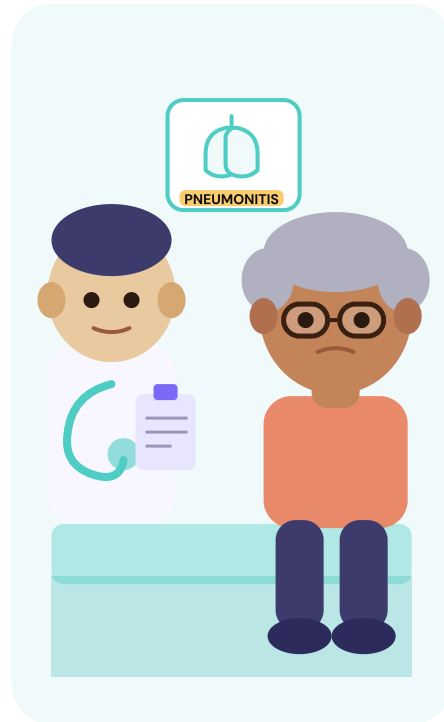
Clinical Evaluation.

Martin's doctor examines him and orders tests, including chest imaging and blood work. The results show signs of drug-induced lung inflammation (pneumonitis). He checks that Martin is not taking any other medications that could be the cause. He also orders more tests to rule out infection or underlying lung disease. He advises Martin to stop taking Relvian.

Over the next two weeks, Martin's breathing gradually improves, and the cough disappears. His oxygen levels return to normal.

DRUG-INDUCED PNEUMONITIS

Inflammation of the lung tissue caused by a medicine. Not listed as a known side effect of Relvian at this point. The timeline, the improvement after stopping the drug, and the absence of other causes all point toward Relvian.

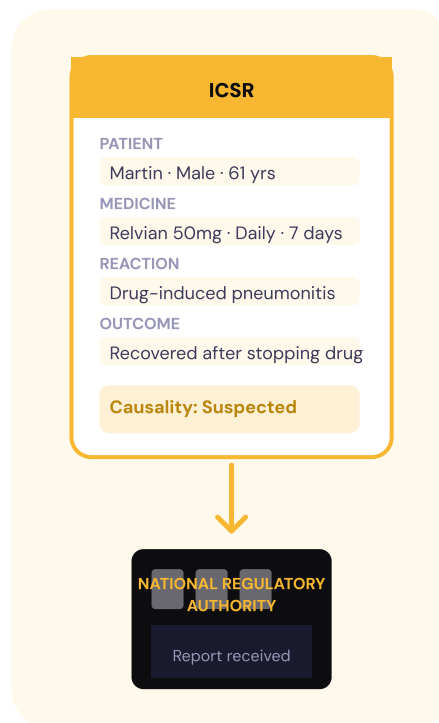


Individual Case Safety Report (ICSR) Submission.

Martin's doctor fills out a report for the adverse event Martin has experienced, as he suspects Relvian may be the cause. Drug-induced pneumonitis was not listed as a known side effect. He sends the report to the national regulatory authority.

WHAT IS AN ICSR?

An Individual Case Safety Report is a formal document describing a single patient's suspected adverse reaction. It captures the patient profile, the medicine, the timeline, the reaction itself, and the outcome. This structured format allows safety databases to compare cases across the world.



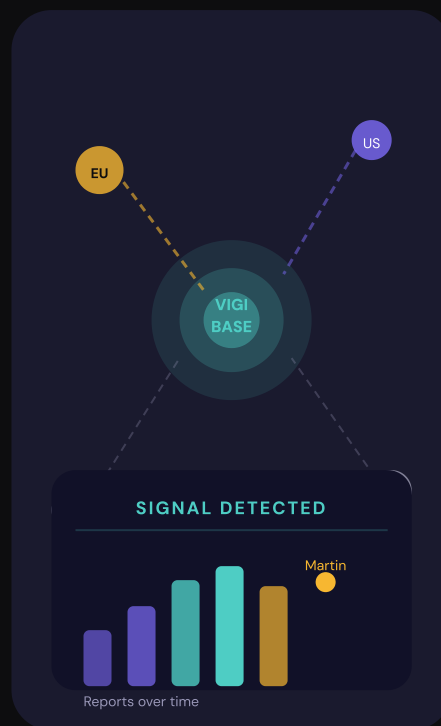
Safety Database Entry, Case Processing and Signal Detection.

Martin's case is added to the national database of adverse event reports for medicines and vaccines. Since the regulatory authority in Martin's country is a member of the WHO Programme for International Drug Monitoring, his report is shared with the global database, **VigiBase**.

At the regulatory authority, Martin's report is reviewed by a case assessor who finds a small number of similar reports involving Relvian and lung inflammation in both the national database and VigiBase. Further analysis suggests it is probable that Relvian may be associated with drug-induced pneumonitis.

WHAT IS A SAFETY SIGNAL?

A signal is information that suggests a new or changed causal relationship between a medicine and an adverse event. It is not proof. It is a trigger for investigation.



Regulatory Action, Label Update and Risk Communication.

The regulatory authority decides that Relvian's manufacturer must update the product information. "Inflammation of the lungs" is added to the list of adverse effects, and a warning is included about the potential risk of serious respiratory reactions.

An advisory letter is sent to health providers, with additional information made available on the regulatory authority's website. Martin's doctor is informed and reviews prescribing guidance.

LABEL UPDATE

"Inflammation of the lungs" added to the list of adverse effects in Relvian's product information.

WARNING ADDED

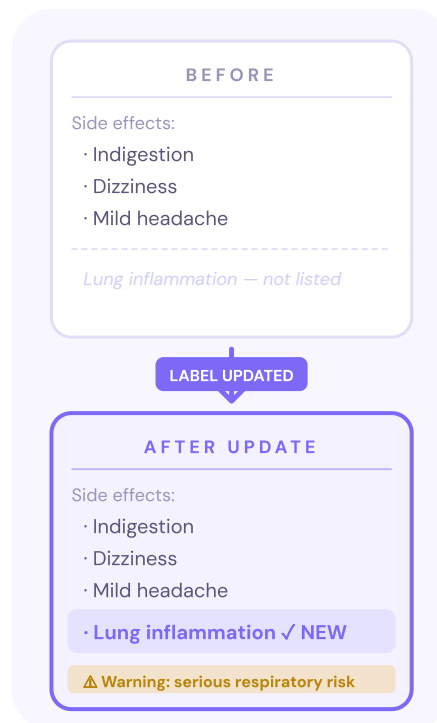
A warning about the potential risk of serious respiratory reactions included in the prescribing information.

ADVISORY LETTER SENT

A direct communication sent to health providers across the country. Additional information published on the regulatory authority's website.

DOCTOR INFORMED

Martin's doctor is informed and reviews prescribing guidance. Other patients on Relvian are now monitored for respiratory symptoms.



Pharmacovigilance Outcome and Risk Minimisation.

Martin's case contributes to a better understanding of Relvian's safety profile. Reports like this help identify rare risks and improve safe use of new medicines.

Martin's doctor switches him to a different osteoarthritis treatment — pain management with physical therapy support and an alternative analgesic — and Martin remains stable with no further side effects.

"Martin didn't do anything extraordinary. His doctor didn't do anything extraordinary. The pharmacovigilance system worked exactly as it was designed to."

WHY EVERY REPORT MATTERS

Clinical trials cannot detect every risk. Some side effects are too rare, too delayed, or too specific to certain patient types to appear before approval. It is the post-approval safety system, built on reports like Martin's, that fills that gap.



Glossary.

Every term from Martin's story, explained in plain language.

PHARMACOVIGILANCE

The science of monitoring medicine safety after approval. It covers detection, assessment, understanding, and prevention of adverse drug reactions.

ADVERSE EVENT

Any unwanted medical occurrence in a patient taking a medicine. An adverse event does not necessarily mean the medicine caused it.

ICSR

Individual Case Safety Report. A structured document submitted by a healthcare professional describing a single suspected adverse reaction in a specific patient.

SIGNAL

Information suggesting a new or changed relationship between a medicine and an adverse event. A signal triggers investigation, not immediate action.

VIGIBASE

The WHO's global database of medicine safety reports. It holds over 30 million reports from more than 130 countries and is used to detect global safety signals.

DRUG-INDUCED PNEUMONITIS

Inflammation of the lung tissue caused by a medicine. In Martin's case, this was the adverse event that triggered the entire pharmacovigilance process.

LABEL UPDATE

A change to a medicine's official product information to add newly identified safety data, such as a new side effect or an updated warning.

RISK MINIMISATION

Measures taken to reduce a known safety risk. These can include warnings, restricted prescribing, advisory letters, and updated guidance for prescribers.

Q Qualivio



Martin's report made medicines safer for everyone.

He did not do anything extraordinary. His doctor did not do anything extraordinary. The pharmacovigilance system worked exactly as it was designed to. Every report matters. Every patient counts.

Qualivio supports pharmacovigilance professionals and organisations with education, consulting, and practical tools built around real regulatory frameworks.

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